During the latter half of the ninth century, the age of empire ended for Tibet, which split into several feuding principalities. The Tang empire too soon came to an end, at the beginning of the tenth century, fragmenting into several Han and non-Han polities.

Tibet's age of empire is marked in Tibetan history as the reign of the three 'Dharma Kings' – Srongtsen Gampo, Trisong Detsen and Ralpacan. They are credited with establishing the Buddhist faith in Tibet. It is during this period that the Tibetan heartland came to comprise three provinces – U-tsang, Kham and Amdo, stretching over the vast Qinghai–Tibetan plateau. It is U-tsang which came to be the central part of this polity, ruled from Lhasa, but over time the other two areas gradually fell under the domination of the Chinese. Parts of Kham in eastern and southern Tibet were incorporated into the present-day Chinese provinces of Kansu, Sichuan and Yunnan. Amdo is in most part the present Qinghai province of China. The current Tibet autonomous region of China is what was previously known as U-tsang.

While China undoubtedly had a significant political impact on Tibet, particularly after its conquest by the Mongols in the thirteenth century (as narrated in Chapter 9), much of Tibet's culture and religion were shaped by influences from India across the Himalayas. Buddhist masters and teachers from the great universities of Nalanda, Vikramshila and Taxila were invited by the rulers of Tibet to spread the dharma in the country and impart its philosophical and doctrinal underpinnings to their Tibetan counterparts. Several Tibetan students were resident at Nalanda when the Chinese pilgrim Xuan Zang visited the monastic university in the seventh century. It was during the reign of the second Tibetan 'Dharma King' Trisong Detsen that the great master from Nalanda, Santarakshita, was invited to Tibet to preach. He established Tibet's first monastery, Samye, in 766 CE . By this time Buddhism was already in decline in most of India, but in eastern India, Tantric Buddhism was becoming popular, borrowing from the popular cult of Shiva and creating a parallel pantheon of Buddhist deities and ritual practices. When Tibetans adhering to indigenous animist and folk beliefs showed resistance to Buddhism, a celebrated Tantric master then resident at